

Handle Success Like You Handle Failure: Learning from Success and Failure, featuring Greg Hiebert

Greg Hiebert, Leadership Coach & Managing Partner

We know the importance of learning from failure, as Pat so eloquently pointed out. Yet surprisingly, learning from success can present even greater challenges. Pat also said, “It's much harder to handle success than it is to handle failure. You have to learn to handle them alike. Only by placing success and failure in their proper perspectives can you maintain the principles and priorities you arrived with.”

That's why I want to examine a commonly made leadership mistake. Too often people get blinded by their success and start believing they are infallible due to their brilliance and overconfidence.

The first challenge is what psychologists call *fundamental attribution errors*. When we succeed, we're likely to conclude that our talents and our current strategy are the reasons for our success. However, we tend to underestimate the role that external factors, situational influences, and random events may have played.

The second challenge is *overconfidence bias*. Success increases our self-assurance and, while confidence in ourselves is a great thing, too much can make us believe we don't need to change.

The third challenge is the *Failure to Ask Why* syndrome, the tendency not to investigate the causes of good performance systematically. When leaders suffer from this syndrome, they fail to ask the tough questions that would help them alter their assumptions and even worse, create the conditions where dissent is not allowed.

Pat Summitt outright refused to engage in the *Failure to Ask Why* syndrome. In fact, not only did Pat ask, “Why did we lose” – she just as regularly asked, “Why did we win?” In an effort to understand the team's performance, Pat was known to relentlessly review film after both wins and losses to determine the source of the team's success or failure.

There's nothing wrong with celebrating your success, but if you only revel in your wins, you've missed a huge opportunity to investigate what led to success with the same scrutiny, the same rigor you might apply to understand the causes of failure. As Coach Summitt said, “The reason success is so hard to duplicate is because we tend to stop doing the disciplined things that made us successful in the first place.”